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Board of Education Report

File #: Res-029-23/24, Version: 1

Dr. Rivas, Mr. Schmerelson - Equitable Access to Vision Care in Los Angeles Unified School District Schools (Res-029-23/24) (For Action June 4, 2024)

Whereas, The Los Angeles Unified School District demonstrates a multi-pronged approach to academic success and equity through the Community Schools initiative, Black Student Achievement Plan, and Priority Schools initiative, aimed at ensuring that all students are prepared and inspired for college, career, and life;

Whereas, The District's Strategic Plan 2022-2026 prioritizes Safe and Healthy Environments to Promote Joy and Wellness, expanding access to vision services aligns with the District's commitment to promoting whole-child well-being through integrated health, nutrition, and wellness services;

Whereas, Up to one-third of children experience vision problems that can significantly hinder their academic performance and overall well-being. These uncorrected issues impede learning as 80% of it is processed visually, leading to difficulties with reading, focusing, headaches, and participation in classroom activities;

Whereas, Limited access to vision care due to provider shortages, affordability concerns, and transportation limitations disproportionately impacts low-income District students, exacerbating existing educational and health disparities;

Whereas, Undiagnosed vision problems can have a negative impact on a student's social and emotional development, leading to difficulties participating in activities and feelings of isolation;

Whereas, A recent report with a study population of over 94% Black and Latinx students published in Journal of the American Medical Association (JAMA) Ophthalmology (2022) demonstrates that participation in a school-based vision program led to significant academic gains in both math and English. Students with Individualized Education Programs (IEPs) and those initially performing lower academically experienced the most improvement;

Whereas, The Los Angeles Unified School District Board previously passed Resolution Res-020-19/20 on March 10, 2020, aimed at increasing equitable access to student health care, and despite these prior efforts, ensuring all students receive the necessary follow-up care remains a critical challenge; and

Whereas, Integrating vision services directly into District schools maximizes resource utilization and removes barriers to care, promoting early intervention through effective school-based programs proven to identify vision problems, connect students with care, and improve academic outcomes; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District commits to furthering

student success by expanding access to vision services through a school-based vision care program offered at no cost to students, families, or the District;

Resolved further, That the Superintendent shall develop a Strategic Vision Care Plan for a pilot program with non-profit organizations to provide school-based initial assessments, diagnosis, prescriptions, prescription glasses, and eye care as needed, that prioritizes service delivery on considerations including but not limited to, designations of Community Schools, BSAP Schools, and Priority Schools during the 2024-2025 school year. Services to be provided on an ongoing basis no less than every other year thereafter. The continued service will help address the changing needs of young children along with students who are new to a school. The vision care plan should prioritize the following:

- **Accessibility:** All services should be offered within school sites during school hours and after-school programming hours to maximize student participation.
- **Quality:** Vendors must be qualified eye care professionals with a demonstrated track record of providing high-quality vision care services to children, have at least five years' experience providing school-based vision services in California, and the ability to bill Medi-Cal for services rendered to covered students.
- **Cultural Competency:** Services should be delivered in a culturally competent manner that respects the diverse needs (i.e. linguistic) of District students and their families.
- **Collaboration with relevant national, state, and local health care agencies:** The Superintendent shall explore and develop partnerships with relevant agencies such as the National Center for Children's Vision and Eye Health, California Department of Health Care Services, Los Angeles County Department of Public Health, children's hospitals, optometry schools, and insurance providers to leverage their expertise and resources in developing a thorough, well-informed pilot program. This collaboration may involve identifying potential funding opportunities through relevant programs and exploring opportunities to integrate vision care services with existing programs that benefit students;

Resolved further, That the Superintendent shall foster ongoing collaboration with stakeholders by engaging educators, administrators, healthcare and vision care providers, school nurses, parents, the Community Schools Steering Committee, and the Black Student Achievement Plan Steering Committee to help inform the development of the vision care plan, address critical issues of equity and accessibility in service delivery, explore potential grant opportunities to ensure the program's long-term sustainability, and work with the Office of Government Relations, the Office of Student Health and Human Services, and any other relevant stakeholders to advocate for related legislation and necessary funding to ensure robust implementation; and, be it finally

Resolved, That the Superintendent shall finalize the vision plan by September 1, 2024, informed by stakeholder sessions as outlined above. This plan will ensure program rollout and service delivery begin within 30 days thereafter.

RECEIPT OF COMMUNICATIONS